

Chapter 131-1

The room had been quiet for a long time.

When Liang Shi became aware of the silence, she tried to communicate with the system again: "Are you there?"

There was no more crackling static, nor that eerie mechanical voice.

Everything seemed as if it had been Liang Shi's imagination.

Looking out through the enormous floor-to-ceiling window, this brightly lit modern city was spread out before her eyes. Stars dotted the distant horizon, and tree branches just sprouting green buds swayed in the wind.

This world suddenly seemed to be covered by a layer of fog in her eyes.

Gradually becoming unclear.

Liang Shi continued: "Send me back. Did you hear me?"

The system gave no response.

.....

After several quiet minutes passed, Liang Shi was disappointed once again.

She curled up on the sofa. The old movie on the TV continued playing from where it had left off, and the peach branches on the coffee table told her that this was spring when all things revive, with the fragrance of flowers and swallows flying in from the south.

This was not that coastal city where you could drive for an hour to reach the sea and see the vast azure ocean.

This was not the place she wanted to go.

She had drunk some wine during lunch with Qi Jiao's family at noon, and had drunk a bit more after returning in the evening. Her consciousness was gradually becoming hazy, and in that haze, she heard that abrupt mechanical voice again: 【Sorry sorry, Host, I'm back.】

Liang Shi: "?"

This time there was no scalp-numbing static—everything was calm.

Yet Liang Shi didn't quite dare to believe it. She remained silent.

System: 【Host! This time! I've really returned!】

Even when the mechanical voice became excited, it couldn't change its fundamentally eerie nature. The suddenly heightened pitch didn't stir any emotions.

Rather, it made one incredulous.

After a long while, Liang Shi finally asked in a low voice: "Can I still go back?"

System: 【Yes! Definitely yes! Previously, due to an error in the atmosphere during transmission, it caused a system malfunction...】

"I don't want to hear why you had problems." Liang Shi said: "I only want to know if you can solve the problem."

System: 【.....】

After a silence, the system said very seriously: 【I hope so.】

Liang Shi: "?"

This garbage system wasn't trustworthy at all, was it?!

The system became anxious. 【Host, listen to my explanation. In the universe we live in, there exist countless plane worlds. Once a deviation occurs in a plane world, it will trigger a butterfly effect. In the Main God Administration Bureau responsible for managing plane worlds, there are many Main Gods each with their own duties. For example, the God of Fortune will bestow luck values upon certain people in various plane worlds, and the Wind God will be responsible for handling wind directions in various plane worlds.】

【All things in the universe have natural laws, but over billions of years of development, deviations inevitably occur. The Main Gods exist to correct these deviations.】

【In the process of correction, occasional mistakes are made, and various bureaus are dispatched to resolve them. However, we follow one principle—conservation of energy. That is, the balance mechanism that Host previously guessed. We try our best to ensure that everyone's life won't be unchanging, whether in prosperity or adversity.】

Liang Shi: "....."

After a moment, Liang Shi asked back: "So Qi Jiao came here because she was suffering over there, and you gave her the opportunity to be reborn? You compensated her with a warm family but stripped her of her memories and intelligence—is that right?"

The system fell silent.

After a few seconds, the system said: 【Sorry, Host. To respect others' privacy, an individual can only view world lines related to themselves and cannot view others' fates.】

Liang Shi: ".....Oh."

She was completely speechless with this system now.

However, from what the system said, she could roughly guess—Qi Jiao was indeed the Qi Jiao from another world.

Liang Shi's previous speculations had all been correct, but.....

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"What about Sun Chengcheng then? She's someone related to my world line. Why can she freely travel between the two worlds?" Liang Shi asked.

When it came to questions related to Liang Shi herself, the system answered quite smoothly:

【It's the butterfly effect produced from correcting Host's world line and setting things right. To put it in a phrase from your human world that you should understand better—everyone has human rights.】

【The Main God treats everyone in all plane worlds equally, and natural laws apply to all humans. The ability to freely travel that she possesses is a double-edged sword born from her obsession.】

These words once again confirmed Liang Shi's speculation.

Sun Chengcheng's traveling ability was related to her own swap.

Liang Shi still wanted to ask more, but the system hurriedly said: 【Sorry Host, after the previous system damage, the Main God Administration Bureau has made a decision to temporarily close the passages between plane worlds to repair each plane world. The time for reopening is unknown.】

That eerie system voice was still speaking when suddenly another deeper, more solemn voice sounded.

This voice sounded more human-like, similar to the radio hosts Liang Shi used to listen to many years ago, but even deeper than that.

He announced at an extremely slow pace:

【The World Gate is about to close. Please choose which world Host wishes to remain in.】

【The World Gate is about to...】

He announced three times in succession. At the same time, a transparent holographic panel with white text on a blue background appeared before Liang Shi.

Option A: World B179 (Current Space)

Option B: World C876 (ABO Space—The world where you were born)

At the very bottom, there was also a line of small text:

[Please strictly abide by the world traveling laws. After making your choice, that world will completely erase all traces of your existence. Given your good performance in the ABO world, after making your choice, your body and soul will be deployed together and cannot be changed. Please choose carefully.]

And at the very bottom, there was a line of red countdown text: 00:15:00.

"Does this mean I have fifteen minutes left?" Liang Shi asked.

System: 【Yes, you can also choose to deploy immediately, and it will take effect instantly.】

Liang Shi asked again: "Is the flow of time the same here and there?"

The system paused for a moment: 【The flow of time in each plane world varies depending on the individual, but for you, it progresses at a 1:1 rate.】

Liang Shi felt reassured. "What about the original owner of that world? Is she still in the interstellar prison?"

System: 【Yes. Please rest assured, Host. Our interstellar prison uses the most advanced and cutting-edge technology. It's impossible for anyone to escape from there, not even a fly.】

Liang Shi: "....."

After experiencing so much turmoil, Liang Shi no longer dared to believe this garbage system's words.

If it was really as it said, then why was she still here?!

However.....

"What's my current state in that world? Also, after my body and soul are deployed there together, what happens to the original body?" Liang Shi asked rapidly.

Influenced by her speaking speed, the system also answered quickly: 【Currently, you are in a coma, similar to your previous state in this world. The original owner's body will be reclaimed by the Grievance Administration Bureau. After you complete your task, the Bureau will submit all evidence to the Interstellar Court to apply for bail and a retrial for her. Once her danger level is reduced to a controllable range, her memories will be erased and she will be deployed into a plane world.】

The system's explanation was quite clear.

And today's system was very easy to talk to—not only explaining the Main God Administration Bureau to her, but also explaining the reasons behind all of this, as well as patiently answering her questions about the original owner.

So easy to talk to that... it didn't seem like the trashy system at all.

While she was thinking this, the system spoke again: 【Due to objective factors causing you harm, the Bureau will also compensate you in certain aspects. This is also the balance mechanism within the world's laws. Now, you have fourteen minutes left to make your choice. If no choice is made by the time limit, it will default to you remaining in this world.】

After saying this, the system paused, then added: 【Also, regarding the content about the Main God Administration Bureau, this portion of your memory will be erased when you are deployed.】

When the AI said this, its tone was somewhat disdainful, as if saying—you, a mere human, don't deserve to know the secrets of our universe.

But Liang Shi wasn't interested in that anyway.

She didn't talk to the system anymore and hurried to say goodbye to everything in this world.

If she hadn't come back, she probably wouldn't have truly realized—she was being loved well by this world.

Emboldened by the fact that in just over ten minutes, everything related to her in this world would disappear, her actions became unusually bold.

Following the press conference that morning where she issued a clarification and retirement statement, she posted on her Moments¹ at 8:47 PM.

【Thank you for this world that has been so accepting of me.

Thank you for truly loving me.

Hello, goodbye.】

As soon as this Moments post was published, many people commented:

[What's wrong? Don't do anything rash.]

[Just live a good life after retiring from the industry. There are many wonderful things in the 3D world²!]

[Sister Shi, I opened a café. Come have a cup of coffee with me tomorrow.]

[.....]

Comments sprouted up like bamboo shoots after rain.

Many of the names were actors who had worked with her—some were A-list celebrities, some were nameless extras. Upon seeing her Moments post, they were all subtly comforting her.

Some directly advised her not to do anything rash, while others made plans with her for tomorrow.

Footnotes:

¹ **Moments (朋友圈)**: A social media feature on WeChat, China's most popular messaging app, similar to Facebook's timeline or Instagram stories, where users can post updates visible to their contacts.

² **3D world (三次元)**: Internet slang originating from anime/manga culture, referring to the real world (three-dimensional) as opposed to the 2D world of anime and fiction. Here it means "real life."

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Liang Shi stared at the screen for a few seconds, conveying her gratitude to the world in this way.

Then she called Wang Zhaozhao.

The one who answered was Xiao Bai, who asked nervously: "Sister Liang, what are you doing? Posting something like that on Moments is really scary. Some friends have been asking me if you're trying to end your life. I'm about to cry from fear."

"No, how could that be?" Liang Shi smiled. "By the way, why are you holding Sister Wang's phone instead of Sister Wang?"

"She's taking a shower." After saying this, Xiao Bai realized something was off and immediately explained: "She left her phone in the living room and forgot to take it. I was just about to call you when I saw you calling her, so I answered."

Liang Shi acknowledged with a soft "okay." She maintained a faint smile throughout, and called out gently: "Xiao Bai."

Xiao Bai responded: "Hmm?"

"Listen well to Sister Wang. Even though she always says she doesn't like you and looks down on you, she actually really likes you. You need to work and live steadily. I still have some money in my account—I'll transfer it all to you later. Life is so short; you need to become a better version of yourself." Liang Shi said: "I hope every day of yours will be as happy as it is now."

Xiao Bai became even more panicked. "Sis, you... why does it sound like you're giving final instructions? This isn't okay, making people feel so upset. You just woke up! Didn't you say you'd be the major investor for my bakery? You haven't even eaten the cake I baked yet..."

As Xiao Bai spoke, she started crying.

"Sis, are you at home? I'm coming to find you right now... You're not allowed to do anything stupid. Since I came here, you and Sister Wang have been the best to me. You don't know how I got through those days when you were in a coma... I, I, I..."

Xiao Bai was sobbing so hard she couldn't speak. Liang Shi's eyes also welled up with tears, but she said gently: "What are you crying for? I really won't do anything stupid. Listen to Sister Wang from now on. Tomorrow—come to my place tomorrow to bake me a cake. What ingredients do you need? I'll go to the morning market to buy them."

Xiao Bai stammered out a few items, and Liang Shi agreed to all of them.

Then Wang Zhaozhao took the phone. Her voice was flat, but even through the receiver, Liang Shi could hear her helplessness.

After a few seconds of silence, Liang Shi said gently: "Sister Wang, take good care of yourself. Find someone who treats you well and have a wonderful romance. Also, look after the little sister. Thank you for these years."

Wang Zhaozhao said coldly: "So you've finally decided?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes."

She said: "Perhaps I was always meant to belong there, to belong to—"

Amidst Wang Zhaozhao's sigh, Liang Shi chuckled softly, her voice becoming even gentler as she said the last two words very quietly: "—her."

Wang Zhaozhao knew she couldn't persuade her otherwise. That serious, cold voice carried a hint of choking up.

One would have thought she'd say something warm, but instead she scoffed lightly: "You really are a love-brained fool."¹

Liang Shi was immediately amused.

Xiao Bai chimed in from the side: "Exactly! Love-brained! Sister Liang, can't you pull yourself together?"

Liang Shi laughed: "Maybe... later?"

Wang Zhaozhao asked: "And what about her? Does she treat you well?"

At the mention of her, those memories in Liang Shi's mind instantly became vivid.

Xu Qingzhu always smelled so nice.

She would tell Liang Shi, "You can kiss me. No need to take responsibility."

She would come to pick her up on rainy days when Liang Shi had drunk too much.

She would accompany her to go crazy and see the ocean in the middle of the night.

She would lean into the car to kiss her when they parted, telling her: "Remember to miss me."

They kissed by the seaside, embraced in their room.

Cuddled together on the sofa watching movies.

Everything she experienced with her was something she had never experienced before.

Liang Shi paused for a moment, her voice filled with sweet laughter: "Very well."

Liang Shi said: "She's also a love-brained fool."

Otherwise, why would she abandon such a promising career and choose to marry her "sister" right after graduation?

Hearing this, Wang Zhaozhao suddenly laughed: "That's good then. Wishing you two love-brained fools a happy marriage. You..."

She paused: "Have a safe journey."

Liang Shi said: "Sister Wang, I'll remember all of you."

—Everything experienced here, and those warm, glittering days of huddling together for warmth.

Wang Zhaozhao laughed: "Mm, I know."

Liang Shi hung up the phone. With three minutes left, she chose to call Qi Jiao.

"What are you doing?" Liang Shi asked.

From Qi Jiao's end came the sound of a pen scratching on paper. She lowered her voice and said: "Writing in my diary. What's up?"

Liang Shi suddenly called out: "Jiejie."²

Qi Jiao: "Hmm?"

"Qi Jiao-jiejie, thank you." Liang Shi said sincerely: "You're not some goldfish brain. You used to be a very, very smart person. Live well, and spend every day as carefree as you are now."

Qi Jiao looked confused: "What are you talking about? Did you drink too much?"

Liang Shi smiled gently: "Then just consider me drunk. But... I want to ask you a question, and you must answer me very seriously."

Qi Jiao was bewildered, but although she didn't understand, she played along: "What is it?"

"If one day you meet Chen Mian, what would you say to her?" Liang Shi asked.

After asking, she added: "Chen Mian is a lonely and melancholic painter who has been unhappy ever since losing her lover. If... if you were her lover, what would you say to her?"

Qi Jiao hesitated and fell silent.

The countdown on the blue transparent screen in front of Liang Shi showed: 00:01:20.

Time was running out.

After hesitating, Qi Jiao answered her question very seriously: "Then tell Chen Mian to remember to listen to 'Flock of Lonely Birds'³ before going to sleep at night. Someone will love her."

Countdown: 00:00:43.

Liang Shi hung up the phone, placed it aside, and clicked on the option at the bottom.

In an instant, scattered fog obscured her eyes, and the entire world fell into a hazy state.

The night of neon lights and fine wine, the steel buildings towering into the clouds—all were tinged with a layer of mist.

Liang Shi felt as if she were floating in the air.

At that moment, the universe and galaxy spread out before her eyes, and everything she had experienced flashed through her mind frame by frame.

Memories were being stripped away from her mind.

Countless blue fragments filled the black background, streaking across like meteors.

She heard that deep voice sound by her ear:

【The World Gate is closing. Wishing everyone a pleasant life.】

Footnotes:

¹ **Love-brained fool (戀愛腦)**: A popular Chinese internet slang term referring to someone who becomes completely consumed by romantic love, often making irrational decisions or prioritizing romance above all else—essentially someone who "thinks with their heart instead of their head" when it comes to love.

² **Jiejie (姐姐)**: Chinese term for "older sister," used both for biological sisters and as a respectful/affectionate term for older women.

³ **'Flock of Lonely Birds' (孤鳥症群)**: Literally translates to "Lonely Bird Syndrome Group/Flock." This appears to be a song title mentioned in the story.

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During that same time period, Sun Chengcheng also heard the same question and faced the same choice.

She chose C876 almost without hesitation.

Changes were constantly occurring across multiple worlds.

Misty blue starlight scattered across the night sky, shattering the black night.

A spring rain fell silently upon the world. Bai Qi, who had just put on her jacket and was standing at the entryway, suddenly felt her vision go dark and nearly fainted. When she steadied herself against the shoe cabinet and stood up, she asked Wang Zhaozhao in the living room somewhat dazedly: "Sis, what was I about to do just now?"

Wang Zhaozhao was holding her phone, watching as the name "Liang Shi" in her call history disappeared before her eyes.

After a moment of daze, she answered: "How would I know? Going to the supermarket?"

"Probably." Bai Qi continued putting on her shoes. "I want to eat ice cream. Do you want some, sis?"

"I don't want any. It's raining outside." Wang Zhaozhao glanced out the window, where rain streaks connected on the glass. "Remember to bring an umbrella."

"Got it." Bai Qi picked up the umbrella at the entryway. She stared at this somewhat unfamiliar yellow Pikachu folding umbrella and asked with slight confusion: "Sister Wang, why do I feel like I've never seen this umbrella before?"

"It was bought at Hengdian¹ before." Wang Zhaozhao glanced at it. "Cost two hundred and thirty yuan."

Bai Qi accidentally pressed the button, and the folding umbrella popped open indoors with a thump.

Wang Zhaozhao frowned. "Can't you be more careful?"

Bai Qi closed the umbrella and pouted: "I remember now. It was when filming with Lu Chenzhou, right?"

"That's right." Wang Zhaozhao said.

Bai Qi put on her hoodie hood and left with the folding umbrella.

But she had forgotten—this umbrella was originally bought by Liang Shi, and it was meant for blocking the sun.

After Bai Qi left, Wang Zhaozhao stared at her phone for a while, feeling empty inside, as if she had forgotten something.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the city, Qi Jiao was sitting by the window with a desk lamp on, writing in her diary, when she noticed rain drifting in. She immediately got up to close the window.

Fine rain threads fell on the glass, condensing into large water droplets. The entire city sank into a watery mist.

On Qi Jiao's diary, only two words had been written: 【Chen Mian.】

But two minutes ago, her diary had contained:

[Liang Shi asked me: If you were Chen Mian's lover, what would you say to her? I want to ask her: Why didn't you come find me? I've been waiting for you for a long time.

Although I never did wait for her, I know she will come.

I just don't know if it's Chen Mian.

This name sounds so familiar, as if I've heard it thousands upon thousands of times, spoken it thousands upon thousands of times.]

Those written words dissipated, as if a clock that had been moved forward suddenly snapped back to its original position.

The trending topic #Liang Shi Moments# disappeared in an instant.

Someone discussed with their friend: "Do you remember what was third on the trending list before?"

"Hmm... now that you mention it, what was it?"

"Forgot. It's probably this current one, right?"

"Wasn't this one fourth before?"

"Then what was third?"

"Can't remember."

"Never mind."

"....."

Beneath the pattering spring rain was a bustling crowd of people.

An abrupt light split open a huge gap in the black night sky in an instant, then closed again in another instant as dark clouds gathered across the sky.

The mottled starlight disappeared into the dark night.

The rain grew heavier.

Footnotes:

¹ **Hengdian (横店):** Hengdian World Studios, located in Zhejiang Province, China. It is the largest film studio in the world and a major filming location for Chinese television dramas and movies. Many historical and period dramas are filmed there due to its extensive replica sets of ancient Chinese architecture.

Chapter 131-5

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Perhaps because it was near the sea, Haizhou City's winters always brought biting sea winds.

The humidity was very high, carrying a faint salty, briny smell.

But it was much better compared to summer.

Xu Qingzhu sat by the window holding a cup of coffee with both hands. Sally and Lin Luoxi were bickering as usual, and as usual, it ended with Sally's defeat.

The weather had turned cold these past few days, and Xu Qingzhu had already put on a turtleneck sweater. Her long hair draped over her shoulders, making her look quiet and warm.

There was a faint red lip mark on the coffee cup. Xu Qingzhu took a light sip of the steaming coffee, and when she set down the cup, her fingernail gently rubbed across the cup's surface, wiping away that touch of red.

She lowered her eyes, and Sally and Lin Luoxi immediately fell quiet.

Sally couldn't help herself: "Blanche, how much longer are you going to stay gloomy? When Liang Shi wakes up and sees you like this, she'll scold us."

Xu Qingzhu's brows furrowed slightly, ripples flowing in her eyes. The corners of her lips gently curved upward into a beautiful arc. "Why would she scold you?"

"You've gotten thinner." Sally said. "She'll definitely say we didn't take good care of you."

Lin Luoxi agreed. "That's hard to say for sure."

Xu Qingzhu spoke softly, her gaze sweeping toward the crowd outside the window, where people strolled past in twos and threes as if taking a leisurely walk.

Her slender, pale hand rested lightly on the light-colored wooden table, her eyelashes fluttering gently as she said in a low voice: "I've actually been eating quite a lot lately."

"Eating and then throwing up?" Lin Luoxi asked. "Is there something wrong with your stomach?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "No, I only threw up that one time."

Last time, she had gone with Lin Luoxi and the others to eat rice noodles outside school, and she threw up on the way back.

No fever, no cold.

She simply threw up after eating too much.

Lin Luoxi had thought this was normal for her.

In fact, Xu Qingzhu had only experienced it that once. It was because they had mentioned Liang Shi during the meal, and she had eaten too much trying to gain some weight. Combined with the bumpy road and Sally's reckless driving, she couldn't hold it in.

The rest of the time, she had been eating well and sleeping well.

Liang Shi had been in a coma for over half a month. Apart from being in a bad mood, everything else was fine.

Work was even busier.

Su Zhe intended to let her get involved in Haiwei's business, and they were working on a collaborative winter collection.

The increasingly busy career allowed her to temporarily forget about Liang Shi's coma.

But memories related to Liang Shi would always surface unexpectedly.

Ever since Sun Chengcheng had conveyed that message to her, the words she whispered most often while sitting by the hospital bed were: "Is it nice over there? Are you happy?"

If Liang Shi could be happy, then she would accept it.

During these long, long nights, sleeping alone and unable to rest, she inevitably thought a lot.

She had imagined Liang Shi's world over and over in her mind.

But she could never quite grasp it.

Without having seen it with her own eyes, how could she know what kind of prosperity existed on her side?

Lin Luoxi noticed her mind wandering and waved a hand in front of her eyes. "Then drink less coffee."

Only then did Xu Qingzhu's scattered thoughts slowly gather. She pressed her lips together in a light smile. "Got it."

"Coffee is only suitable for people like Sally who would die if they didn't sleep ten hours a day." While comforting Xu Qingzhu, Lin Luoxi didn't forget to throw shade at her own girlfriend, drawing Sally's resentment. But with one look from Lin Luoxi, Sally immediately became as quiet as a quail.

Lin Luoxi said: "You already have insomnia, and you're still drinking coffee. Can you even sleep at night?"

"It's okay." Xu Qingzhu said. "I can sleep over seven hours every night now."

It was just that the light sleep state lasted quite a while, and she always slept on and off.

Seeing her like this, Lin Luoxi could only sigh helplessly. There wasn't much she could do.

Instead, it was Sally who said: "Don't you have a Taoist temple around here? Should we go pray tomorrow? I heard it's very effective. Or a Buddhist temple would work too."

Lin Luoxi: ".....You're certainly not picky."

Sally flipped her hair: "Whoever can bless us, we'll believe in them."

Lin Luoxi: "....."

She didn't know if Sally had learned the essence of Chinese people's approach to praying to gods, or if people all over the world were like this.

When trouble arose, everyone had to pray—as long as one of them worked, that was enough.

When nothing was wrong, they only believed in themselves and would tell others that all of that was superstition.

But Lin Luoxi thought this was also a solution.

Even if praying to gods and Buddhas didn't work, at least it would count as taking Xu Qingzhu for a stroll up the mountain.

It was just that in winter, there wasn't much good scenery along the way—far inferior to summer.

Coastal cities' winters and summers each had their own advantages.

"How about we go to Yunfeng Mountain tomorrow?" Lin Luoxi said. "Last year, a friend of mine went there to pray, and she got pregnant this year."

Xu Qingzhu was surprised. "Yunfeng Mountain doesn't handle childbirth matters, does it? It's not like it has Songzi Guanyin.¹"

"Sincerity makes it effective." Lin Luoxi said. "They're already immortals. What can't they do?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Lin Luoxi continued: "Only us mortals are powerless."

Xu Qingzhu was somewhat persuaded. After a moment of silence, she laughed softly. "That's true."

There was still a hint of bitterness in that laugh.

Lunch break ended, and they left the coffee shop together.

Sally shielded her eyes with her hand and looked up at the cold sun in the sky.

The sky was azure blue—not a very clear azure, with a few white clouds floating in it.

¹ **Songzi Guanyin (送子菩薩/送子觀音):** Literally "Child-Sending Guanyin," this is a form of the Bodhisattva Guanyin (Avalokiteśvara) specifically associated with fertility and childbirth. Women who wish to conceive often pray to this deity. The point being made is that Yunfeng Mountain's temple doesn't specifically house a fertility deity.

Chapter 131-6

There were many companies on this street, and people who had eaten outside were gradually returning to their office buildings.

The wind had picked up.

Xu Qingzhu raised her hand to pull her collar tighter.

Sally said with some regret: "Why hasn't it snowed this year yet?"

"Who knows." Lin Luoxi said. "The weather forecast says it'll snow tonight."

"Will we be able to see snow like we had back in university?" Sally asked.

Lin Luoxi paused: "That depends on the heavens."

Xu Qingzhu remembered the snow from that year. That day, the snow was so deep it nearly reached people's calves, and the area below the dormitory building was full of people having snowball fights.

It was a rare heavy blizzard in Haizhou City. Many people didn't go to work, and even the buses stopped running.

It just so happened that day was a Sunday.

She and Bai Weiwei had made plans to go out and get their hair done. Bai Weiwei wanted to get her hair permed into curls and dyed brown, and asked if she wanted to do something too. She spent a long time choosing on her phone and eventually picked an inconspicuous milk tea gray that even faded slowly.

They went to the salon together to get their hair done, and it was still snowing outside while they were there.

At the time, people in the shop said the snow would last a day and a night.

Bai Weiwei even joked—surely it wasn't the end of the world?

That snowfall was exceptionally heavy and left a deep impression on Xu Qingzhu.

She had just come of age back then. On the way back to school, Bai Weiwei received a call from her father and went straight home, leaving her to walk back to school alone.

On the way back, she bought milk tea for a person lying face-down in the snow.

That person was lying motionless on the vast white snow, as if dead.

She walked over and poked them, and the other person said in a muffled voice: "Scram."

That person had blue-dyed hair and was only wearing a black sweater and a pair of very thin pants.

Xu Qingzhu, who was wearing a padded jacket, felt cold just looking at her. She had no idea what kind of performance art the other person was doing.

As it happened, Xu Qingzhu had two cups of milk tea in her hands. One was bought for Bai Weiwei, but Bai Weiwei had left.

So she placed that cup of milk tea on the snow. Upon contact with the heat source, the snow rapidly melted, as if creating a cup holder for the milk tea.

Xu Qingzhu's clear voice mingled with the wind and snow: "Drink a cup of milk tea to warm yourself up, then go home."

After saying this, she stood up to leave.

But that body that had been lying face-down in the snow suddenly sat up. Her face was covered in white snow, looking utterly disheveled.

That person asked coldly: "What's your name?"

Xu Qingzhu turned around and saw the other person's face covered in snow—not just that, but her sweater and pants were also covered in snow, almost blending into the heaven and earth. It looked somewhat funny.

As a teenager, she didn't know how to hide her emotions at all. If she found something funny, she laughed.

Only after laughing did she say: "Xu Qingzhu."

"You should live well." Xu Qingzhu said.

That was a rare occasion when she spoke to a stranger.

Xu Qingzhu remembered this particularly well.

Because that person looked like they wanted to die that day.

That heavy snowfall happened shortly after they had started university. Since then, Haizhou City's winters never had such heavy snow again.

Sally said with some regret: "I want to have a snowball fight."

"How old are you? So childish." Lin Luoxi complained.

Sally: "....."

Xu Qingzhu continued listening to the two of them bicker.

When she returned to the company, Zhou Yi'an was waiting for her in the office.

Chapter 131-7

Xu Qingzhu was surprised: "You didn't go eat lunch?"

"I've been thinking about it for two days." Zhou Yi'an said very solemnly. "I still had to come ask you."

"What?" Xu Qingzhu sat in her chair, her hand resting casually on the desk.

"When did Liang Shi change?" Zhou Yi'an asked. "Or rather, how long did she remain as she was before?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"What answer do you want?" Xu Qingzhu asked her in return.

Zhou Yi'an pressed her lips together, then threw the question back at her: "What answer are you willing to tell me?"

"What that woman said that day—it should have been Liang Shi passing a message to you." Zhou Yi'an rotated the decorative ring on her finger. "So where is she now? And where is... the person from before?"

From the night Zhou Yi'an had called her, Xu Qingzhu knew this conversation was coming.

Zhou Yi'an was very smart. She could easily deduce a clue from Sun Chengcheng's words.

And then confront Xu Qingzhu with conclusions that were half-guessed and half-reasoned.

Xu Qingzhu paused for two seconds and could only answer honestly: "I don't know."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

"We suspected before that Liang Shi had a split personality." Xu Qingzhu said. "But later we realized that probably wasn't it. If you really want to know the answer, perhaps only Liang Shi can answer that question for you."

Zhou Yi'an lowered her eyes, the motion of rotating her ring becoming faster.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, and when their eyes inadvertently met, she suddenly asked: "So you liked the original Liang Shi?"

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

As if unwilling to admit that she and Xu Qingzhu liked the same person—that Xu Qingzhu had won while she had not—her answering voice was very soft, almost a very low hum: "Mm."

"Why did you like her?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhou Yi'an: ".....There isn't always a 'why' for everything."

Zhou Yi'an's tone was sharp, but she had already restrained herself somewhat.

This was already her restrained self when angry. She furrowed her brows: "So where has the current Liang Shi gone?"

"I don't know." Xu Qingzhu answered again.

Somewhat powerlessly.

Zhou Yi'an raised her eyes to look at her. "Then what do you know?"

Xu Qingzhu: ".....Do you have to speak so sharply?"

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

The office fell quiet.

After a moment, Zhou Yi'an said: "You'll never know what it's like to find someone like yourself..."

"Sis sis sis!" Su Meiqi's voice came from outside. She knocked once on the door and pushed it open, directly interrupting Zhou Yi'an's words. As soon as she entered, she rushed straight to the desk like a gust of wind, staring at Xu Qingzhu with a serious expression: "I might know why Sister Liang hasn't woken up from her coma."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hmm?"

Su Meiqi widened her eyes and held up one finger: "She very likely traveled back to her own world!"

"Do you know the concept of parallel universes?" Su Meiqi said. "That's what it is. Otherwise, I really can't figure out why she would be in a coma for so long when advanced medicine can't explain it."

Su Meiqi said seriously with furrowed brows: "If one day she really can't wake up, it's very possible that all our memories will be erased. Or she'll just die, or she might wake up with a different personality—all of these are possible!"

She rubbed her chin. "What do you think—if I wait for a ten-planet alignment¹ to try transmigrating, would my chances be good?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Just as she was daydreaming, someone flicked the back of her head.

The force wasn't light either.

Su Meiqi covered her head and looked back, finding Zhou Yi'an staring at her eerily.

Su Meiqi: "....."

She said plaintively: "Sister An, when did you get here? You walk without making any sound. Also, stop hitting me—you've already knocked me stupid."

"You still know that you need a ten-planet alignment to transmigrate." Zhou Yi'an scoffed lightly. "You don't seem that stupid."

Su Meiqi: "....."

Speaking of this, Su Meiqi became energized. Her eyes sparkled: "Or a nine-planet alignment would work too. Failing that, there are also legendary treasures, newly opened wormholes—generally, any unusual celestial phenomenon is a good opportunity to transmigrate."

"How did you study physics and politics in school?" Zhou Yi'an raised an eyebrow. "Did you buy your way into that prestigious university? Why do you believe in such things?"

Su Meiqi instantly lost her composure and loudly argued back: "Existence is reasonable!² You can't say something doesn't! Exist! Just because you haven't seen it yourself!"

"Do you know that using a sick person for your fantasies is very impolite?" Zhou Yi'an said coldly.

Su Meiqi: "....."

"Bold hypotheses, careful verification?"³ Su Meiqi said this with less conviction. She looked at Zhou Yi'an, then at Xu Qingzhu, and finally pouted: "Sorry, sis. I was just saying."

Zhou Yi'an grabbed the back of her neck. "Skipping work to play around with your 2D stuff here⁴—do you want your dad to find out?"

At the mention of her dad, Su Meiqi jumped up like a mouse whose tail had been stepped on, immediately protesting: "Zhou Yi'an! You're going too far! You're a grown adult and you're still tattling to parents—you're being completely unreasonable!"

Zhou Yi'an pinched the back of her neck and threatened coldly: "What did you say?"

Su Meiqi: "....."

The two of them left Xu Qingzhu's office.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu sat in her office contemplating the possibilities of what Su Meiqi had said.

During her precious work time, she spent an hour researching those theories.

In the end, she discovered—she really had fallen for Su Meiqi's nonsense.

Setting aside the fact that unusual celestial phenomena were rare occurrences that might not happen once in ten years, just the stuff online about special constitutions and the like was obviously meant to fool children.

It was probably just a case of desperately seeking any solution.⁵

Xu Qingzhu suddenly laughed at the answers displayed on her computer.

Then she saw a message Zhou Yi'an had sent an hour ago: 【Don't discuss transmigration with chuunibyou⁶ girls.】

Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen and smiled.

Who would have thought that someone as contrary as Zhou Yi'an would also have considerate moments.

She replied with an "mm" and said nothing more.

Footnotes:

¹ **Ten-planet alignment (十星連珠)**: A rare astronomical event where multiple planets align in a row. In fiction and popular culture, such celestial events are often portrayed as triggers for supernatural occurrences like time travel or transmigration.

² **"Existence is reasonable" (存在即合理)**: A philosophical statement often attributed to Hegel, meaning "What is rational is actual and what is actual is rational." It's commonly used (sometimes incorrectly) to argue that anything that exists must have a reason for existing.

³ **"Bold hypotheses, careful verification" (大膽猜測，小心求證)**: A famous quote from Chinese scholar Hu Shih about the scientific method—make daring hypotheses but verify them carefully with evidence.

⁴ **2D stuff (二次元)**: Refers to the world of anime, manga, and related fiction. "2D" (two-dimensional) contrasts with "3D" (three-dimensional/real life). Here, Zhou Yi'an is dismissing Su Meiqi's transmigration theories as anime-inspired fantasies.

⁵ **Desperately seeking any solution (病急亂投醫)**: A Chinese idiom literally meaning "when seriously ill, one will try any doctor." It describes someone in desperate circumstances who will try anything, even unreasonable solutions.

⁶ **Chuunibyou (中二)**: A Japanese term (adopted into Chinese internet slang) referring to the "eighth-grader syndrome"—adolescent delusions of grandeur where teenagers believe they have special powers or knowledge. Here it's used to describe Su Meiqi's fantastical theories about transmigration.

Chapter 131-8

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Being busy with work could, to some extent, ease the longing.

After getting off work, Xu Qingzhu went to the hospital as usual.

It was while driving to the hospital that she noticed her phone kept buzzing.

And outside, it was snowing.

Snowflakes danced and drifted down from the sky, landing on her car windows. The snowfall was quite heavy.

The windshield wipers kept brushing away the falling snow.

Xu Qingzhu felt it was a bit stuffy in the car, so she opened the window just a crack.

Wind and snow drifted into the car through the gap, carrying the chill unique to coastal cities.

The heater was still running in the car, so the snow immediately melted into water droplets as soon as it drifted in.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly thought—if Liang Shi were here, she would definitely ask whether this was for the cold or for the heat.

Xu Qingzhu murmured: "Maybe it's just stuffy."

Being alone was stuffy.

Sitting alone in the car was stuffy.

Even with music playing, it still felt stuffy.

Her phone vibrated frequently. When waiting at a red light at an intersection, Xu Qingzhu picked it up to take a look. Sally had posted many snow scene photos in the group chat. Having not seen snow for so long, she was going crazy playing in the snow.

And Lin Luoxi was photographing Sally.

Sally was catching snow with her bare hands, all ten fingers frozen bright red.

Seeing them having fun, Xu Qingzhu replied: 【What's this? Luring the dog in to slaughter?¹】

Sally: 【On-site slaughter.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Blow you up.jpg】

After casually replying to the messages, Xu Qingzhu continued driving forward.

The cars on the road gradually increased. As dusk approached, the street lights lit up in an instant, illuminating the city's night.

In the distant sky, a shooting star streaked rapidly across.

Watching Sally and Lin Luoxi show off their love daily was nothing new.

She had been watching since university.

But lately, she would think in countless moments—if only Liang Shi were here.

But Liang Shi wasn't here.

So she seemed very lonely.

Xu Qingzhu parked the car in the parking spot at the hospital entrance, still holding a bouquet of flowers she had bought from the flower shop downstairs.

When she got off work, the flower shop was about to close too. Flowers that had been sitting all day were on clearance sale, so she bought a bouquet of sunflowers, planning to replace the baby's breath in the hospital room that was about to wilt.

Her cream-colored long trench coat made her figure look tall and slender. Because of the extremely cold weather, a rosy flush had appeared on her fair face from the cold—at least it saved her from applying blush.

Xu Qingzhu walked into the hospital holding the flowers, attracting quite a few stares along the way.

It was probably rare to see such exceptional looks.

She walked forward as usual, her heart like a pool of still water, calm and undisturbed.

At first, she was walking with her head down, but after nearly bumping into someone, she finally looked up to watch the road.

Just as she was about to reach the entrance of the inpatient ward, she suddenly stopped in her tracks.

A figure came rushing out of the inpatient ward entrance like the wind. She was wearing blue and white striped hospital pajamas, with a light brown trench coat that Xu Qingzhu had left in the hospital room casually thrown over it. It was a bit small, but probably because she had been lying in bed for so long recently, her figure had become even more slender, so it didn't look bulky on her. The color of the coat matched her pupils exceptionally well.

The fluttering white snow seemed to have a rhythm, drifting freely under the street lights.

Blown about by the wind in a wild dance, without any direction.

Xu Qingzhu gripped the sunflowers in her hand tightly.

That figure stopped after rushing a few steps out of the inpatient ward. The two of them stood still simultaneously, gazing at each other across the sea of people.

Glistening hot tears welled up in their eyes.

The flying snowflakes landed on both of their eyelashes, melting instantly.

After a long while, Liang Shi's tears fell. She didn't care about that—she simply opened her arms and called out to Xu Qingzhu in a gentle voice: "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu's feet shifted slightly, terrified that this was only a dream.

She licked her lips and responded in a low voice: "Hmm?"

Liang Shi said: "Come here."

She paused, then said the next sentence in a choked, halting voice: "Don't you want to hug me?"

The sunflowers in Xu Qingzhu's hands fell to the ground in that instant. She ran a few firm steps toward Liang Shi and threw herself directly into Liang Shi's arms.

Liang Shi's arms tightened around her. She bent down slightly, her gentle voice carrying infinite tenderness and attachment, continuing from her previous words:

"I've missed holding you so much, Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, tears falling onto her shoulder, her arms hugging tightly around her waist.

"Liang Shi." Xu Qingzhu called her name.

Liang Shi released her and lowered her head to gaze at her.

Liang Shi's voice was very low. Her hand caressed the side of her face, her fingers tracing along her jawline, the corners of her eyes reddened: "Xu Qingzhu, have you not been eating properly again?"

Xu Qingzhu's tears fell onto the back of her hand. "I have been eating."

"But you've gotten thinner." Liang Shi said with heartache.

Xu Qingzhu stared into her eyes, then suddenly closed her eyes. Tears dripped down again, like little pearls.

Liang Shi felt the back of her hand burning. The spot where the tears fell felt like it had been burned by a cigarette, piercingly painful.

"I'm back." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu's clear, cold voice almost merged with the wind and snow. She asked with extraordinary caution: "Is this a dream?"

"No." Liang Shi said. "I'm back. I'm not leaving anymore."

She slowly bent down, while Xu Qingzhu slightly tiptoed.

Their cold lips, carrying a snowflake between them, met in a kiss.

The snow was cold; the lips were warm.

In this moment, they belonged to each other.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Luring the dog in to slaughter"** (把狗騙進來殺): Internet slang used when couples show off their affection publicly, making single people (jokingly called "single dogs" in Chinese internet culture) feel envious or attacked. Xu Qingzhu is playfully accusing Sally and Lin Luoxi of deliberately posting cute couple content to "hurt" single people watching.